This is a wonderful, unusual, inspired soup. The combination of saffron and curry powder gives it an interesting aromatic quality.

mussel and saffron soup

SERVES 4 **PREP TIME** 15 MINS **COOK** 35 MINS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

½ cup dry white wine
2 cups fish or chicken stock
4½lb (2kg) mussels, scrubbed and debearded
2 tbsp butter
4½oz (125g) onions, finely chopped
2 carrots, diced
3oz (85g) celeriac, diced
1 thin leek, finely sliced
1 garlic clove, chopped
1½ tsp curry powder
good pinch of saffron threads, soaked in 2 tbsp hot water
1 cup heavy cream
salt and pepper
2 tbsp parsley, finely chopped

1 Bring the wine and stock to a boil in a large deep pan over high heat. Add the mussels, discarding any that will not shut when tapped, and cover. As the mussels open, remove them to a bowl. When all are open, filter the liquid through muslin into another bowl. Discard two-thirds of the shells.

2 Clean the pan. Melt the butter over low heat and add the vegetables and garlic, stirring well. Cook gently for 10 minutes, then stir in the curry powder and add the mussel liquid and the saffron in its water. Add the cream and cook without boiling for 5 minutes. Return the mussels to the pan, heat through gently, and season well. Sprinkle over the parsley, and serve.

SCRUBBING AND DE-BEARDING MUSSELS



Scrub the mussels under cold running water, then scrape off any barnacles with a knife.



Pinch the dark stringy "beard" between forefinger and thumb and pull it firmly away.